

The Crow and the Pitcher

During a long, dry summer, a crow flew across fields searching for water. The ponds had shrunk to mud, and the streams were thin. By afternoon his throat was dry and his wings felt heavy. At last he saw a pitcher standing beside an abandoned cottage. He landed beside it and looked inside. There was water at the bottom, clear and cool, but the narrow neck of the pitcher kept his beak from reaching it.

The crow tipped the pitcher with his claws, hoping to spill some water onto the ground. It was too heavy to move. He pushed, pulled, and flapped his wings against it, but the pitcher barely shifted. A young lizard watched from a stone nearby. "Perhaps it is impossible," the lizard said. The crow did not answer. He knew that giving up would not make his thirst disappear.

Near the pitcher lay several small pebbles. The crow picked one up and dropped it into the water. A tiny splash rose, and the water level lifted by almost nothing. He dropped another pebble, then another. The work was slow. Each stone seemed too small to matter, and the lizard soon grew tired of watching. But the crow noticed that the water had risen a little after every few stones.

He continued until the sun was low. The pitcher gradually filled with stones, and the water climbed toward its narrow mouth. At last it came close enough for the crow to drink. He took a long, grateful sip. The water had been there all along; what he needed was not greater strength, but a different idea and the patience to carry it out.

Before flying away, the crow looked at the remaining pebbles. He remembered how useless they had appeared when he first saw them. From that day, whenever he faced a difficult problem, he looked carefully at the small things nearby. A single small action may not solve a problem, but many thoughtful actions can change what once seemed impossible. The lizard, who had returned to see the result, carried that lesson with him as well.